British reticence. Kennedy believed that “India is the important thing; not the UK.” It was indispensable to the effort to “stop Communist China.” He asserted, “Let’s not be penny wise about India; let’s not let them get into a position where they feel that they can’t cope with the Chicoms and Paks on top of their other problems.”[75]

The discussion turned to a subject on which there had been more agreement: air defense. After the war, Harriman had let Nehru know that American, British, and Indian officials would continue to discuss air assistance.[76] The UK and US had sent a team to India to explore this option. Both Galbraith and Komer had suggested an Anglo-American “air umbrella.”[77]

At the April meeting, McNamara said that an air umbrella had “great political value” and was more cost-effective. Bowles and Komer thought the US should move forward on this as well. Kennedy stated, “If the Chicoms bombed India [the US] would of course become involved” so there was not “too much risk in giving a prior commitment.” Deputy Assistant Secretary of State James Grant suggested that it would also buy time with India, in terms of showing US willingness to help India, while American and Indian officials worked out a more realistic military assistance plan. Rusk expressed the concern that “shooting at Chicom planes in India would lead almost certainly to the Chicoms shooting at us elsewhere. It would immediately broaden the war.” He wanted to hold on a commitment until he and Sandys returned from a trip to India. In the meantime, to indicate American willingness to assist India, there could be defense talks about the possibility of “sending the US/UK air defense squadrons” to aid India.

Kennedy agreed, but did not want to wait too long. He emphasized, “We want the Chicoms to know what we are going to do so they won’t attack.” Furthermore, he wanted military assistance talks to continue and the State Department to stay away from them so that “we didn’t appear to tie the talks too much to political conditions such as Kashmir.” He noted that the administration should also prepare Congress for an air defense commitment. After all, “Congress would be much madder if India went Communist.” Air defense had other advantages: it was cheaper, could deter Chinese action against India thus obviating the need for American intervention, and was less likely to cause problems with Pakistan. If India